passed away in 2013, claimed to have ‘brought back’ over 1,50,000 tribals into the Hindu fold.[8]

Fresh evidence unearthed from the archives in the course of my research shows that the ABVKA was birthed amidst a major national debate—on the role of foreign Christian missionaries and conversions—within Nehru’s government as well as the larger Congress Party between 1953 and 1955. This debate raged over three years in Parliament, once again pitting Nehru against the Congress’s Hindu traditionalists whom he had vanquished in 1951 to take back control of the party machinery (see Chapter 9). This was the second major debate on ‘communal’ issues, after the 1950-51 dispute on Hindus left behind in Pakistan, which set Congressman against Congressman.

The debate on conversions became such a flashpoint that, three years after his decision to attend the opening of the newly reconstructed Somnath Temple in Gujarat, President Rajendra Prasad clashed yet again with the prime minister. Twice in the year 1954, the president of India publicly warned missionaries to stop conversions. Nehru reacted with reassurances to minorities in Parliament, detailed missives to Congressmen and a nuanced pushback. Importantly, several Congress-run state governments (UP, Madras, Assam, Madhya Pradesh) sent in detailed reports to Home Minister K.N. Katju, asking for measures to end conversion. Katju himself made strong statements in Parliament. This relatively less-known debate ended with the Government of India and Prime Minister Nehru issuing a new policy in 1955, imposing restrictions on foreign missionaries. The debate on religious conversion was unfolding at a time when Nehru faced serious internal opposition from the Congress’s Hindu traditionalists as he piloted the Hindu Code Bills for religious reform. All of this formed the backdrop to the creation of the RSS-run ABVKA.

Most opponents of the Sangh think of it as a hydra-headed monolithic entity, all the components of which work in unison as part of a masterplan to re-engineer society. The origins of the ABVKA, dedicated to inculcating a Hindu identity among tribal communities and one of forty-plus organisations that make up the wider Sangh Parivar, show how simplistic such a notion is.